INNOVATIVE DESTRUCTOR

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SURYAKUMAR YADAV
Cricketer

If bats could speak, Suryakumar Yadav's willow would have drowned all other noise. He has pretty much recast batting in white ball cricket

By Amitabh Srivastava



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One can well describe the advent of Suryakumar Yadav and his magical ability with the bat as a starburst illuminating the oversaturated galaxy of white-ball cricket. Yet, all of those shots—physics-defying uppercuts, scoops and lofted drives—that leave us goggle-eyed have had a long gestation: trials and failures totted up and analysed, then refined and honed to perfection.

If the term '360 degree batter' was coined for A.B. de Villiers, the title now inarguably rests with India's Suryakumar Yadav, aka SKY, the conjurer who unlocks gaps on a cricket ground that other batsmen cannot dream of. In November, Surya became the world's number one T20 batter after his exploits at the T20 World Cup, where he scored 239 runs at a strike rate of 189.68 and an average 59.75—extraordinary for a T20 batsman. Moreover, in a starry batting line-up, SKY is now the mainstay.

Suryakumar has rocked the shorter formats. Scoops, sweeps, flicks are executed with bat gradients that demoralise the opposition

The impact of Surya, however, goes much beyond numbers. His preternatural ability has rubbed off on others. When Ishan Kishan scored the fastest ever ODI double century in Bangladesh, he was compared with Surya. In the shortest possible time, SKY has become a benchmark against which others are measured.

Till now, shorter formats have seen the best of Surya—punchy uppercuts, the dramatic crouch to short-of-length balls pitched on the off-stump before they're dispatched for sixes over fine-leg, trademark shuffles across the crease, the fast switching of leg positions for inside-out drives or inside-the-line pulls. Scoops, sweeps, flicks are executed with bat gradients that demoralise the opposition and tear apart coaching manuals.

It now seems unbelievable that SKY had to warm the bench for long before making his international debut against England in 2021. Since then, whenever he is out in the middle, a game is split in two: when Surya is at the crease, swiveling on an axis of his own, smashing up the bowling, making the game a compulsively watchable thriller, and when he's at the non-striker's end. This past year has seen the arrival of a batting sensation. We breathlessly await his impact on Test cricket. ■